

**LUCIA CORMIER VS. MARGARET CHASE SMITH:
DEBATE FOR THE MAINE SENATE SEAT,
NOVEMBER 5, 1960**

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1960 is often remembered as the year Americans witnessed the first televised presidential campaign debate. There was another political campaign “first” that year, however, one that received national attention at the time, but that has been largely forgotten today. Each of the major political parties in the state of Maine nominated a woman to be its candidate for the U.S. Senate that year. This was the first time two women ran against each other for a U.S. Senate seat, a situation that did not occur again for twenty-six years, and has been repeated only four times.¹ Democrats nominated Lucia Cormier, minority leader in the Maine House of Representatives, and Republicans continued their support of incumbent U.S. Senator Margaret Chase Smith. In addition to national publicity, the campaign culminated in a debate between the two candidates, which was broadcast on both radio and television, Sunday, November 6, from 5:00-5:30 p.m., two days before the election.

The historical significance of this debate lies not only in the fact that it was a “first” for women, but also in the forgotten fact that it represented a culmination of forty years of growing political activism among women. *Time* magazine’s September 5, 1960, cover story on the race began by asserting “Next Nov. 8 will very likely go down in history as Ladies’ Day, with women voters outnumbering men for the first time in any peacetime presidential election”(p. 13). The article continued:

In many areas, a feminine candidate is a required entry on any well-balanced ticket, and across the land more bonnets than ever before are in the political ring. Three

women are running for the U.S. Senate, 26 for the House of Representatives, more than a hundred for legislatures and other statewide offices, thousands for county and local political jobs that range from board of education to justice of the peace. The nation's biggest, most eyecatching feminine contest is building up in Maine, where two women are matched, for the first time ever, in a race for the U.S. Senate (p. 13).

This two-woman contest, therefore, reflects the significance of women's expanding activity in local and national politics throughout the period from 1920-1960, women who were not victimized by the "feminine mystique," but who established a foundation for the revived women's movement of the 1960s.

This example also provides a theoretical touchstone for scholars interested in contemporary political campaign strategies generally, but pointedly in a woman vs. woman campaign. Every woman who runs for public office is challenged to create a favorable political identity as a female political leader; one who is perceived as both capable and strong without violating gender role expectations. Attacking the opponent, essential for a challenger and central to any good debate, is particularly difficult for a woman candidate and doubly problematic in a woman vs. woman campaign. If a female candidate directly attacks another candidate, she risks violating gender role expectations for women, and any direct attack on a female candidate contradicts "the cultural tendency to protect women" (Proctor, Aden, & Japp, 1988, p. 191; see also Sheckels, 1994; Trent & Friedenberg, 2004).

This brief account of the debate and its political context illustrates how Smith, with textbook precision, managed the contingencies of her Senate campaign and broadcast debate to win the race with the largest margin of any Republican Senate candidate that year (Smith, 1972). Although in retrospect Smith's campaign victory seems a foregone conclusion, at the time Democrats believed they had found a way to successfully challenge Maine's popular

¹ In 1986 Barbara Mikulski (D-MD) defeated Linda Chavez (R); in 1998 Patty Murray (D-WA) defeated Linda Smith (R); in 2002 Susan Collins (R-ME) defeated Chellie Pingree (D); in 2002 Mary Landrieu (D-LA) defeated Suzanne Haik Terrell (R).

“lady” Senator. Removing the male vs. female gender confrontation by nominating Lucia Cormier seemed like a solution to the Democrats’ problem.

The Candidates

The two-term incumbent, Republican candidate Margaret Chase Smith, had already distinguished herself in the U.S. Senate as a disciplined, hard working, independent Senator. Smith’s entry into the Senate in 1948 gave her the distinction of being the first woman elected to the Senate in her own right, and the first woman to serve in both houses of Congress. Furthermore, she was the only Senator to denounce the actions of fellow Republican Senator Joseph McCarthy in a speech, her “Declaration of Conscience,” delivered on the Senate floor. She faced significant and unusual challenges in both of her previous Senate campaigns, the first one in the 1948 Republican primary where she was told the Senate was “no place for a woman.” In her 1954 re-election bid she defeated a primary opponent hand-picked by Joseph McCarthy. But in the general election that year, although Smith won a clear majority for her Senate seat, an energetic newcomer, Democrat Edmund Muskie, picked up the Governor’s seat.

Lucia Cormier, minority leader in the Maine House of Representatives, applauded her Democratic colleagues in 1954, noting a significant weakening of traditional Republican strength in Maine, and a diminished majority for Smith (Sherman, 2000, p. 138). In 1958, Muskie defeated Republican incumbent Frederick Payne for the Senate, leaving Smith the sole Republican in the Maine Congressional delegation. If she could be defeated, then Muskie would become Maine’s senior senator, heading up a 100% Democratic delegation from Maine. Cormier was Muskie’s choice to run against Smith in the 1960 Maine Senate race.

A Franco-American fluent in French with an M.A. from Columbia Teacher’s College, Cormier was a former schoolteacher and owner of a profitable stationery and gift store in Rumford. During her twelve terms in the Maine House of Representatives, she served as Democratic floor leader and was also a national committeewoman for the

Democratic National Committee (Cormier). Cormier was ten years younger than her opponent, an experienced and effective leader in state politics, with a natural constituency among Maine's francophone population. Maine political columnist, Lorin Arnold, said she was "the most efficient, most sincere, and hardest-working woman legislator ever to grace the legislative scene" (Mills, 2000). Given her demonstrated competence and experience in state politics, combined with Muskie's support and an explicit endorsement from John F. Kennedy, Cormier had the credentials to give Smith a run for her money.

Turning to the debate itself, as McKinney and Carlin (2004) and Trent and Friedenbergl (2004) document in their literature reviews of political campaign research, one analytical approach is to place the debate within the narrative of the campaign as a whole. This is the approach that gives us the clearest sense of how the Cormier-Smith debate functioned in the 1960 Maine Senate race, particularly in relationship to Cormier's mounting attacks during the last six weeks of the campaign. While at first glance it may seem that Smith did not respond to the attacks until the last minute during the debate, a closer look reveals that her entire campaign was adjusted in response to the attacks, much as Barbara Mikulski "responded" to Linda Chavez in their 1986 U.S. Senate race in Maryland (see Sheckels, 1994). Smith emphasized her record and incumbent status and avoided direct confrontation with Cormier until the debate, at which point Smith skillfully turned her opponent's attacks into questions about Cormier's character. Thus, the broadcast debate foreshadowed some of the functions that televised political ads serve in contemporary campaigns.

The Campaign

Cormier kicked off her campaign in February with a visit to Washington, DC. Muskie gave her a tour of the Senate, suggesting she sit in one of the chairs to get a feel for her new job, and he set up a photo-op with Cormier and three other Democratic Senators. Smith found Muskie's behavior lacking in collegiality, and she seemed to focus more on him than Cormier in her campaign (Smith, 1972, pp. 242-243). Meanwhile, Smith

maintained her independent voting record in the Senate, earning the ire of Barry Goldwater who, as head of the Senatorial Campaign Committee delayed providing Republican Party funds for her campaign (Sherman, 2000, p. 159). Smith did not even attend the national Republican convention that year, which, as *The New Republic* reported “was just as well for the convention planners kept her off the program, and her colleague, Barry Goldwater, who does not trouble to hide his dislike for Mrs. Smith’s independent streak, managed most ungallantly either to ignore or to forget her when he called the roll of November’s Republican Senatorial nominees” (“Ladies,” 1960, p. 6).

According to Smith, calls for a debate between the two Senate candidates came early in the campaign. Maine reporter, Don Larrabee, assigned to Washington, suggested a national debate between the two women. Although Smith claims she never refused to debate, she said privately she was opposed because she felt televised political debates were more “sadistic entertainment than constructive enlightenment,” that “it was a well established political truth that a debate is more advantageous for the challenger than the incumbent,” that Lucia “would win easily because she was a trained and skilled debater,” and, finally, she did not want to give any hint of the appearance of a “cat fight.” (Smith, 1972, pp. 243-244). Furthermore, given the equal time regulation that had been in effect for Smith’s entire political career, she also spurned every request for an interview from the broadcast media. She reasoned that if she granted an interview, then, by law, Cormier would have to be given equal time, thus gaining free and easy publicity. Smith also feared the very real possibility of a “fake debate” made up of cut and spliced segments of interviews that created the effect of a debate between the two candidates (Smith, 1972, p. 244).

So the two campaigners followed similar paths, meeting with voters in small groups throughout Maine, focusing on issues and avoiding personal attacks and the image of a “cat fight.” Although Smith foiled attempts of broadcast media to compare and contrast the two candidates, creating some tension with those reporters, print media did publish stories of the campaign, picturing the two women head-to-head, juxtaposing them visually in a debate-like

pose. Most notable was the September 5, 1960, cover of *Time* magazine, which pictured Smith in front facing left and Cormier just behind looking right. The article asserted “Separately, the ladies from Maine will fight their political battle without catcalls. Together, they are the symbols and the harvesters of the long, bittersweet struggle for women’s rights” (p. 13).

According to Smith, however, Cormier went on the attack during the last six weeks of the campaign. Smith did not respond to the specific attacks or counter-attack, but campaigned on her record of achievements (Smith, 1972, p. 247). When approached early that fall by Portland radio-television station WCSH-TV about a debate in Maine on the Sunday before the election, both Smith and Cormier agreed. Cormier, now on the attack, may have believed that this was an opportunity for her to finally demonstrate her opponent’s vulnerability. Smith, on the other hand, used the debate, strategically, as an opportunity to answer all attacks and, as we will see, turn the tables on her opponent before the largest audience of the campaign.

The Debate

Expectations

Expectations for the debate were that the women were well matched as debaters, with, perhaps a slight edge granted to Cormier. She was the college graduate, fluent in three languages, and minority floor leader. She was not only the popular Muskie’s pick, but also had highly visible support from Presidential candidate John Kennedy. Furthermore, Smith was consistent in her praise of Cormier, stating later, perhaps disingenuously, that she was convinced Cormier was the better debater. Smith herself, continued to campaign locally, earning some negative publicity through her refusal to grant broadcast interviews (Cheshire, 1960; Smith, 1972; Sherman, 2000). Also, Smith’s unwillingness to respond to Cormier’s attacks prior to the debate may have created the impression that Smith would not be up to the challenge of a debate, where she would have to respond to the seemingly more aggressive Cormier.

While several print stories in the month before the debate tended to present Smith somewhat more favorably, Cormier was, nevertheless, generally given credit as being a worthy, if not very strong opponent. For example, a November 2, 1960, *Waterville Morning Sentinel* article entitled “Senate Contest Matches Two Ladies,” said:

There is a plausible suspicion that Miss Cormier would like to provoke Senator Smith into a public show of the temper the venerable Skowhegan politician is thought to possess. But, so far at least, the prospect of the political equivalent of a female hair-pulling bout is decently dim. . . . Senator Smith has never underestimated her opponents in any of her many campaigns and it is not likely she is doing so in this one. There is no question that in Miss Lucia Cormier she has a forthright scrapper on her hands (p. 1).

Furthermore, the fact that Cormier was given equal press coverage with Smith created the impression that the two candidates were equally strong contenders. As a September 3, 1960, editorial in the *Kennebunk Star* lamented “Comparisons of the two ladies are everywhere to be read, but we have yet to find one stating preferences.” Even this editorial, explicitly favoring Smith, could be read as implying Cormier would be a tough debater, given their conclusion: “Visually, here is our major observation: Miss Cormier, despite the roundness of form and feature, looked a bit hard and sharp; Mrs. Smith, despite the leanness and angularity, looked soft and well-rounded.” Adding to the impression that Cormier would be a tough opponent in the debate was the sense, as in the *Kennebunk Star*, that she was somewhat masculine in temperament, thus implying she would be more aggressive and potentially more effective in a verbal face-off.

All of this, ultimately, played into Smith’s hands. It seemed that Cormier was at least her equal, and perhaps the stronger debater. It was expected that Cormier would attack as she had been doing in the six weeks prior to the debate. Smith, meanwhile, continued her “above the trenches” approach to the campaign in public, and prepared for the debate with characteristic diligence and attention to detail. Her aid, Bill Lewis, compiled a notebook including every argument made by her opponent during the campaign along with answers

and documentation. Smith studied the notebook, practiced her opening and closing statements until she felt so confident and comfortable, she reported later, that she began to look forward to the debate (Smith, 1972).

The Debate

The format was the same as the Presidential debates: two minute opening and closing statements by each candidate; questions from a panel of four journalists; comments on each other's answers. Smith won the coin toss for the closing statements and elected to go last. Cormier won the toss for opening statements and, to the surprise of Smith and her advisor, Bill Lewis, elected to go first. To date, no recording or transcript of the debate has been located. Smith's notebook with opening and closing statements, plus her arguments and evidence for every point is included in her papers at the Margaret Chase Smith Library Center (MCSLC) in Skowhegan, Maine. Newspaper accounts, however, can be pieced together to get at least some sense of what each candidate said.

Cormier's opening remarks included reference to "the 'great issues' of the campaign . . . the international situation, domestic problems and specific problems in Maine" ("Sen. Smith," 1960). Smith followed by taking a completely different approach. She began with a backhanded personal attack on Cormier:

At the outset of this discussion, I want to state my attitude and feeling toward my opponent. Although she has repeatedly characterized me throughout this campaign as being cold and arrogant, not caring about the older persons and the working people, of insulting the intelligence of Maine voters, ridiculing my voting record, implying that I was afraid to debate, chiding me for my independence of thought in not always agreeing with all Republican candidates on all issues, and making other attacks on me –in contrast, throughout this campaign I have never made an attack on her or voiced criticism of her. Instead I have expressed respect and praise for my opponent saying that she was the finest Senatorial candidate the Democrats could have selected.

We have no record of specific comments Cormier made in her closing statement, but Smith returned to her theme, stating, "In my closing statement I return to setting the record straight on some of the direct and indirect attacks my opponent has made against me." She concluded with quotes from three prominent Democrats, Governor Clinton, Senator Muskie, and Congressman Oliver, in which each offered their praise of Senator Smith.

Thus, Smith turned the debate into a defense plus acclamation of herself and her accomplishments and, in so doing, indirectly but powerfully attacked her opponent's character. Also working to Smith's advantage was the fact that she so often joined Democrats on issues of direct concern to Maine voters such as labor and federal power projects, so there was no actual disagreement on many important issues. Smith's theme in her campaign and in this debate was herself: her experience, her work ethic, her character. Earlier Smith was reported as saying the only issue in the campaign was "whether the people of this State want a Senator with 20 years of good service on the national level, or whether they want someone whose experience has all been in state legislation" (Cheshire, 1960). She made that the focus of her opening and closing remarks and interspersed answers to various attacks made on her during the campaign within the rest of the debate. Cormier was left with very little room to distinguish herself in a positive way from Smith. There was no significant disagreement over issues, and Cormier had not established a clear definition of her leadership style. If anything, she looked and sounded more like a schoolteacher than a Senator ("The Candidates," 1960; Cormier & Craig, 1960).

Postdebate

Because the debate ended with Smith's statement, viewers were left with the impression that the Democratic Party endorsed Smith rather than Cormier. According to Smith's account, Cormier's aide "dashed up to the panel and charged that the questioning had been rigged to the disadvantage of Miss Cormier" (Smith, 1972, p. 254). Cormier spoke at a rally later that evening in Lewiston, Maine where she "denied that she had attacked Sen. Smith on such issues as federal aid to education and depressed area legislation. 'I did no

such things,' she said. 'I have mentioned repeatedly my opposition to the stand of her party of these issues'" ("Sen. Smith," 1960). John Kennedy was also on the platform at that rally, and he opened his remarks by greeting "Senator Muskie, Congressman Oliver, Congressman-to-be-Donovan, Senator-to-be Lucia Cormier – I hope; she will be a wonderful one – Dave Roberts, the next congressman from his district. . . ." Although he voiced strong support, the insertion of "I hope" indicates that the debate did not go well for Cormier. It was not, as may have been anticipated, a repeat of Kennedy's successful 1952 Senate campaign debate that put him ahead in the race against venerable Massachusetts Republican Henry Cabot Lodge (Trent & Friedenbergs, 2004, p. 272).

Smith, on the other hand, never underestimating her opponent, and aware that her previous Senate campaign had shown some weakening in support, used her status as incumbent to stay above the trenches during the campaign. During the debate, she reminded voters of her independent voting record, and through meticulous attention to detail, she focused the debate on her strengths in contrast to what she characterized as her opponent's misleading attacks. The result, just two days later, was a landslide in Smith's favor, setting her up for a national contest against the growing conservative wing of the party led by Barry Goldwater.

Conclusion

This historic debate remains instructive in a number of ways. First, methodologically, we see the value of analyzing a campaign debate within the overall narrative frame of the campaign. By examining the debate within the campaign context, it becomes apparent that Smith used the broadcast debate as an opportunity to respond directly to Cormier's attacks. In this sense the debate served one of the important functions that would later be met by televised political ads. Secondly, though overt attacks and responses remain the most obviously accessible strategies for analysis, it is important to look beyond them in order to uncover the covert, backhanded, less defensible tactics. This debate, particularly in the power of Smith's final statement, exemplifies successful strategizing and

preparation that built on images of victimization at a point when they could not be challenged. Third, this debate underscores the presence of specific, gender-based challenges to credibility, whether in the form of overly detailed descriptions of physical and personal grooming or stereotypical anticipation of “cat fights” and the changing nature of these challenges. Finally, the debate documents women’s activity and significance within the heart of political parties and campaigns at a point in time when later feminist theorizing would have us see only an absence rather than a presence, a presence that would grow into the formidable force of the next few decades.

In sum, this historic “first” is instructive as a historical moment but remains significant because it provides valuable case data and a forum for testing and revising our theories of campaign practice and response.

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